to Bhutan, built new monasteries also in the Paro Valley and in Bumthang, where he set up his headquarters.

Guru Rimpoche is regarded as the founder of the Nyingmapa sect of the tantric Tibetan form of Mahayana Buddhism that spread throughout Bhutan in the eighth century. Nyingmapa is also known as the 'old sect' or the Red Hat sect.[9] But neither today's Bhutan nor Tibet had any properly organized central governments at that time. Local kings ruled different areas and were often at war with one another, and rival sects fought for spiritual supremacy over the subjects. Mongol warriors had also entered the scene and settled in some of the region's most fertile valleys, and, in Tibet, helped the first Dalai Lama gain political power.

By the fourteenth century, the power of the Mongol overlords began to decline, but, after a period of anarchy, the Gelugpa, or the Yellow Hat sect, which the Mongols supported, became the most powerful force in Tibet. As a result, monks of rival sects fled to eastern Tibet and headed south to Bhutan. Some of these monks built the first fortified monasteries, called *dzong*s, that still dot the Bhutanese landscape. Eventually, the practices of a subsect of the Red Hats called Drukpa became the dominant form of religious practice. The Drukpa school emerged as the most powerful force, especially in western Bhutan, and, as Bhutanese historian Karma Phuntsho writes, 'in later times came out victorious to become the ruling power and state religion'.[10]

But still, no reasonably centralized state structure existed until the Drukpa monk Ngawang Namgyel arrived in Bhutan in the early seventeenth century. He had fled the dominance, in Tibet, of the Yellow Hat sect, which was led by the fifth and most powerful Dalai Lama. Ngawang Namgyel assumed the title '*shabdrung*' (at whose feet one submits) and repelled repeated attempts by the Gelugpa rulers of Tibet to conquer his new realm. The most vivid account of the shabdrung's strong personality was compiled by a Jesuit priest from Portugal who met him in 1627. The priest, Estevao Cacella, was accompanied by another Jesuit, Joao Cabral, and these two Portuguese men were the first known Westerners to visit Bhutan. Cacella described the shabdrung as 'both King and highest lama in this kingdom'.[11]

Since the seventeenth century, the country has also been called Druk Yul, the land of the thunder dragon, to emphasize the Drukpa lineage.